

NT6242: Sermon on the Mount

Dr. Jowers

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Week # 10 Essay on the Two Paths and Book Report

“Jesus is Savior, but not Lord.” Can this statement be possibly true?

I don’t think so. If Jesus is Savior, that means that the gospels are true, and the Gospels clearly say that Jesus is Lord.

Denying the Lordship of Christ is denying the truth of the gospel, and this is the controversy between the Two Paths that Bill Mounce describes in the Sermon on the Mount.

You see, there are two paths. One path is hard suffering to achieve eternal life. The other path is easy going Christianity with a looseness that still barely achieves eternal life. And so we see the contrast already - one takes hold of life firmly, while the other is loose and barely survives the test of salvation.

There are two equivalent controversies of these two paths. Costly grace, and cheap grace; also, the Lordship salvation controversy.

John MacArthur, in his article,¹ “A 15-Year Retrospective on the Lordship Controversy,” writes about the Lordship-Salvation controversy. This controversy is regarding the two paths that Bill Mounce talked about.

Mounce talked of a path where a person is saved but doesn’t follow sanctification, and another path that is hard where a saved person follows sanctification and the cross. This is essentially the same two paths that MacArthur is talking about when he says that a believer should have works, while the opponents of MacArthur says “those who call unbelievers to surrender to Christ's authority are preaching a gospel of works” (MacArthur).

¹ MacArthur, John. “A 15-Year Retrospective on the Lordship Controversy.” *Grace to You*. Accessed December 9, 2025. <https://www.gty.org/articles/A100/a-15-year-retrospective-on-the-lordship-controversy>

According to Macarthur, these people “objected to any kind of evangelism that employed the language of denying oneself, taking up a cross, and following Christ (cf. Matthew 16:24; Mark 8:34; Luke 9:23)” (Macarthur). They say, these are “all matters that pertain to discipleship rather than saving faith.”

Macarthur says, “Divine grace doesn't guarantee heaven in the afterlife while merely overlooking the evils of this life. Authentic grace is the undeserved favor of God toward sinners, delivering them from the power as well as the penalty of sin (Romans 6:14)”.

“Grace is dynamic, "teaching us that, denying ungodliness and worldly lusts, we should live soberly, righteously, and godly in the present age.”

“Grace is not merely God's response to the sinner's initiative. Quite the opposite. Because He is gracious, God takes the initiative, drawing the sinner (John 6:44, 65), granting repentance (Acts 3:26; 5:31; 11:18), and awakening the heart to faith (Acts 13:48; 16:14). “

And this is the point that I want to emphasize the most. Grace is a wonderful gift, as Ephesians says, but it causes us to do the works. We are not doing the works on our own strength or even will. Thus, the opponents of Macarthur and Mounce are saying, “I don't want to work hard! It's too burdensome. Give me freedom to live freely and do what I want even as a Christian!” And in some sense, I understand this. Paul was accused of antinomianism three times in Romans - and why? Because Paul almost preached antinomianism - he was very close. Why? Because, like in Galatians, Paul says that we do not live under the law and that the law doesn't apply to us anymore. We don't have to work. But I want to emphasize, God works in us so that we joyfully work.

Thus I think the problem with Macarthur and Mounce's opponents is that they don't have the joy or the greater gift of obedience to Christ. They may believe, and this is salvific, but they don't have the greater gift of carrying the cross extensively. If they don't carry the cross at all, they wouldn't believe at all, because faith always produces works because God always works grace in us. But God's grace can be very weak in power in some, and allow them to sin greatly.

It is the great Christians who are disciplined and shun evil, like Apostle Paul. And they do it, not because they have a burden on them that tells them to live righteously, but because God's love constrains them and propels them forward to a righteous life.

"For by grace you have been saved through faith, and that not of yourselves; it is the gift of God" (Ephesians 2:8).

"He graciously gives the sinner a new heart and a new spirit of obedience (Ezekiel 11:19-20; 36:26-27; 2 Corinthians 5:17)" (Macarthur).

So, I agree with Macarthur, and I think that to solve this controversy, we need to tell the opponents, "You can simply believe. But God wants you to carry the cross."

According to Holloway,² in his article, "A Return to Rome: Lordship Salvation's Doctrine of Faith," a different perspective is preached. He says, "but MacArthur, in a chapter entitled 'The Nature of True Faith,' repeatedly speaks of obedience itself as constitutive of faith. For MacArthur good works are no longer merely the product of saving faith. They are an integral part of it."

² Holloway, Paul. "A Return to Rome: Lordship Salvation's Doctrine of Faith." *Journal of the Grace Evangelical Society*, September 1, 1991. Accessed December 9, 2025. <https://faithalone.org/journal-articles/a-return-to-rome-lordship-salvations-doctrine-of-faith/>

This is essentially, the “Medieval Roman Catholic understanding of “formed faith” (fides formata), the very notion that Luther repeatedly attacked in his famous 1535 commentary on Galatians.”

“He treats the relationship as one of a whole to its parts (works being a part of saving faith).”

“MacArthur writes that faith ‘encompasses obedience,’ and that obedience is ‘an integral part of saving faith.’”

“Luther is adamant that unadorned faith saves, that is, faith in Christ, without the Law or works.”

What we see here is that Holloway is criticizing those of Lordship-salvation with the heresy of Catholicism. He presents Catholicism and Augustine and Aquinas in a shoddy light, and Luther in a good light. But is that correct?

Luther says, Faith without the Law saves. But isn’t that a shoddy faith? Wouldn’t it be much better for this Faith to be adored with many jewels and the beauty of a righteous life? Essentially, Luther is saying evil and unrighteous Faith saves. I really believe that Luther had too many sins.

And so I take the stance that yes, Faith alone without the Law saves, but that is not the ideal. The ideal which we should aim for is Faith with the Law.

In the next paper by Sojka,³ we see the concept of costly grace and cheap grace, as expounded by Bonhoeffer. Bonhoeffer was a great advocate of Luther - both of them were German. This is in contrast to the above article, which says that Luther says that Faith Alone

³ Sojka, Jerzy. “Dietrich Bonhoeffer’s ‘Costly Grace’ as a Reminder of Reformation Theology.” *Theologica Wratislaviensia* (2016).

without the Law saves, but Bonhoeffer will say that you need the Law and Lordship of Christ in order to be saved with Faith.

It's all very confusing at this point who's saying what. And I think the point is: this is all squabbling. We know the answer: believe God. This will cause us to draw near to him and be sanctified.

Sojka says that Bonhoeffer defined cheap grace as “preaching forgiveness without repentance; it is baptism without the discipline of community; it is the Lord's Supper without confession of sin; it is absolution without personal confession.”

In fact, the 95 Theses has it as well. The “Ninety-Five Theses or Disputation on the Power and Efficacy of Indulgences from 1517, which reads: “When our Lord and Master Jesus Christ said, ‘Repent’ [Matt. 4:17], he willed the entire life of believers to be one of repentance.”

This shows that Luther preached repentance along with Faith. So which did Luther preach? Costly grace or Faith Alone? It's a muddled mess. But I believe what Luther and Bonhoeffer are saying is that costly grace means that Faith will always be accompanied by works, although Faith is separate from works.

Sojka says, “whereas the Law cannot be omitted, because without it there is no chance for a true penance.” This means that we need the Law although we are saved by faith alone by grace alone.

Pruitt⁴ says in his paper, “Lordship and Free Grace Salvation: Repentance in Luke-Acts,” that repentance is simply a changing of mind, and that is all that is necessary for salvation.

⁴ Pruitt, Jon. “Lordship and Free Grace Salvation: Repentance in Luke-Acts.” Senior Honors Thesis, Liberty University, April 2008.

It is now a 3rd approach that we find here. It is like a mid-way point between the two extremes. One extreme says you have to follow the Law, the other says that you don't need the Law at all, and now Pruitt is saying, simply assenting to Christ's Law without doing it is following the Law and is salvific.

This is because repentance literally means that one changes his mind. This does not mean that he changes his actions. And thus,

“Concerning repentance as a change of mind about Christ, Ryrie states: “That kind of repentance saves, and everyone who is saved has repented in that sense. So in salvific contexts, repentance has at least two characteristics: it is only a change of mind about Christ and is necessary for salvation.”

Thus, we see that the action of repentance, the actual changing of one's behavior and not sinning anymore, is not necessary for salvation. “Repentance, in Hodges view, is better seen as part of the sanctification process.” And sanctification is a good thing we must all do, but it is not what is part of salvation.

I think it's an important thing to note that Hodges is not advocating that we are not to be sanctified. He is simply stating in scientific terms that salvation consists with Faith alone without the Law, but Christianity, which is larger than Faith alone, and also the Bible, consists of more than just Faith - it consists of things like sanctification, for example.

And so we see that this debate is a scientific debate of terminology and definitions. What is Faith? What is the law? What is repentance? What is salvation? It is a terminology game and none of these respected theologians are wrong or heretical - they are simply talking past each other, and it is a muddled mess.

Once again, the author states, “Currently, there is great debate over what Jesus Christ meant when He called sinners to repentance...repentance is turning from sin; a gift given by God and not a work.”

And I think this is an important point to make and emphasize again - that regardless of what definition you take of Faith in relation to the Law, it is grace and God’s work that causes us to do the Law or follow the Law.

“The gospel calls sinners to faith joined in oneness with repentance.” And this is true because the Gospels say that Jesus proclaimed, “Repent!” So, we need to repent, but what does that mean? And do we actually need to do it because the Sermon on the Mount has impossible commands.

You see, the Sermon on the Mount says, “Be perfect.” How can I or anyone be perfect? We are all sinners. And so where is the boundary line between, “This is what Jesus preached and I need to do it,” and, “This is what Jesus preached and I need to do it.” Another boundary may be, “I have faith, but no Law,” and “I have faith, but I try to burden myself with the Law.” Or maybe a better way to put it is, “I have faith that works out the Law through grace.”

Nash⁵ says Lordship-salvation can be defined as, “Submitting to his [Christ’s] sovereign authority.” The opponents say that you can believe in Christ and yet reject him as Lord.

To this I must say, this is absolutely false. I don’t care about the argument or controversy, Lordship is an issue about what is the Gospels. Jesus is Lord, this must be true for everyone because this is a fact and a spiritual truth we must assent to. I understand that we can say that

⁵ Nash, Ronald. “The Controversy Over Lordship Salvation.” In *Great Divides: Understanding the Controversies That Come Between Christians*. NavPress, 1993.

Jesus is Lord, yet I don't completely follow him perfectly or even obey him much at all. But we should assent to the fact and assert that it is true.

How can someone say that Jesus is just an ordinary man and yet be saved? He is not Lord in this case.

I think we need to define the Lordship of Christ a little bit more in detail in order to understand the truth of the matter.

Thus, I believe that you cannot - absolutely cannot - accept Christ as only Savior and not as Lord. This is not the Jesus we serve and believe in. Jesus is Lord and Savior.

They say, "those who have not bowed to Christ's scepter...are deceived."

Stott says, they think they "can enjoy the benefits of Christ's salvation without accepting the challenge of His sovereign Lordship."

And to this I will say, I believe someone can be saved without the hardness of Christ's sufferings. But this is an infant on milk and not on hard food. We must not overly burden new believers with hard food.

So, once again, this is all a definition game.

One other issue is justification. MacArthur says "without obedience there is no justification and no heaven." This is a controversial issue because justification is not the same thing as faith. Faith may always include works, but justification is by faith alone, not by works. And so we see we have another delicate definition game.

In conclusion, we see that the lordship-controversy is intense and important. If we claim that we don't need to call Jesus Lord, we are essentially tearing up the Gospels. But I understand what they are trying to say: they are trying to say we cannot follow Jesus as Lord perfectly

because we are sinners. But I think we should still call Jesus Lord even though we are sinners and cannot follow him perfectly.

And justification is by faith alone, but faith may or may not include works in its definition. But MacArthur believes that justification requires works, which is a hard saying to say.

Thus, we have a definition game - where we need to define what is Faith, Law, Works, Repentance, and Justification. Everyone is right, and no one is preaching heresy: we just need to define our terms correctly.

And so Bill Mounce's Two Paths say that there are two paths. And I must say both are true, but we should follow the path of the cross - of suffering, and difficulty, to achieve life.

Book Report

I found it very informative to read 5 different commentaries at the same time. And surprisingly, I found each of them to say similar things. One of them was more geared toward real-life examples to explain the Sermon, and another (Stott's) was very theological and exegetical.

I thought it was very important to learn about every word and interpretation of the Sermon. I learned how to interpret verses, not just books of the Bible.

Each concept was nuanced, and incorrect thoughts were explained away.

I was particularly impacted by the exegesis on anger and lust. What I remember was that anger can be okay and righteous if used correctly, and that lust goes to the heart of the matter of adultery.

And so what I found was that the Sermon on the Mount was going to the heart of the matter. Jesus said, “You wash the outside, but the inside is disgusting!” And Jesus is now cleaning the inside of our hearts.

I found that Stott was a very good writer and that he explained everything very clearly.

I found that I love reading Stott’s commentary and that I want to be a professor. It is much more comforting to read Stott’s commentary on a depressing day than to read Computer Science or the news.

I found that Stott had a good interpretation on whether the Sermon on the Mount is something we should actually do, or if it is okay to follow the path of no-lordship. I found Stott to say that we are in the middle - we cannot do all of the Sermon, but we should not do none of it.

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